Cornell University Physical Intelligence

Sponsorship
2026 - 2027

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Who we are

Cornell University Physical Intelligence is a student research organization that builds robots where the mechanics, the electronics, and the autonomy are designed together. On a real machine those are not separable problems, and treating them separately is how most student robots end up working in a demo and nowhere else.

Thirty-five students work across four subteams on projects that run for several semesters. Almost everything is made in house: we cut the frames, lay out and assemble the boards, and write the code that flies them. Members join a project rather than a task queue, and most stay with it long enough to see a design go from a sketch to something that flies badly to something that flies well.

What we are actually asking

Most of our work comes down to one question: how much of a robot's intelligence can live in its body instead of its code. A leg with the right compliance needs less control. A camera in the right place needs less computation. Building the hardware and the software at the same time is the only way we know to find where that line sits.

In practice that means aerial, ground, and manipulator platforms, all of them instrumented, and all of them expected to run outside a simulator. A robot that only works in simulation has not told us anything we did not already assume.

Where we are

Thirty-five active members across four subteams. Two papers published this year out of the autonomy group. One national competition entered, with the first qualifier cleared. Three platforms in the shop at any given time, in various states of working.

How the team is built

Mechanical

Frames, linkages, and drivetrains. Takes what software and electrical need and turns it into something that can be machined and will survive being flown into a wall.

Electrical

Boards, power, and firmware. Every PCB on our robots was laid out, assembled, and debugged by a student.

Software

Perception, control, and autonomy, running on the actual hardware with real sensor noise rather than in a simulator.

Business

Funding, recruiting, and keeping projects documented well enough to survive a graduating class.

What we are building now

Symbiote

A quadcopter and a hexapod that cover the same site together. The drone maps from above, the hexapod reaches what the drone cannot see, and the two share what they find over a radio link running on boards we designed.

Anduril AI Grand Prix

A national autonomous drone racing competition run with the Drone Champions League. We cleared every gate of the first virtual qualifier with a policy that contains no neural network at all, and have published two papers on the work since.

How a project runs

A project starts with one person who wants a thing to exist and ends, if it goes well, with a machine and a write-up. In between it is mostly failure: parts that do not fit, boards that do not power on, and controllers that work on the bench and not in the air. We budget for that, because it is where the learning is.

What a sponsor actually sees

Updates when something works and when it does not, an invitation whenever we fly, and your name on the machines these students will be talking about in interviews for the next five years.

Why this needs money

We are not short of ideas or people. We are short of parts. Actuators, carbon, custom PCB runs, compute for training, and competition entry fees are the direct limit on how much we get built in a year.

Sponsorship also buys students something harder to price. Undergraduates rarely get to own a system end to end, from the machining through to the control loop, and the ones who do tend to be the ones who go on to build real things.

Every dollar goes to the team. We are a registered student organization, so there is no overhead taken out along the way, and we will tell you exactly what your money bought.

Tiers

Bronze $500+

Logo on the CUPI website, project updates through the year, and access to the student resume book.

Silver $1,500+

Everything in Bronze, plus your logo on project materials, early access to technical write-ups, and an invitation to our lab demos.

Gold $5,000+

Everything in Silver, plus prominent placement on the robots and displays, a recruiting session or workshop with the team, and first look at what we build next.

Getting started

Email us and we will send back a one-page proposal for the year: what we intend to build, what it costs, and where your name goes. If you would rather see the machines first, we will bring one to you.

If this is the kind of thing you want more of in the world, we would like to talk.

We are happy to come to you, show you the machines, or send a longer write-up of any project in here.

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